REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 03



Priority Whiplash

THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Show what the new yes displaces. Leave with an explicit choice instead of invisible overtime.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

WORKING EDITION / REBEL-LEADER.COM

The new request might matter. What would it replace?

You're the PM carrying a team plan while urgent requests keep arriving. You need a way to welcome opportunities without quietly creating another promise.

Make the existing work visible

People often ask for new work without seeing the commitments it would interrupt. Put the request beside what customers and colleagues already depend on.

Turn urgency into a tradeoff

Ask what needs to happen, why now, and what consequence makes it urgent. Then name what would move if the request enters. The useful question is which outcome deserves the next available capacity.

Your win as the PM

Give the decision owner an explicit choice, protect essential conditions, and update the people affected. You can recommend a change without making the team absorb it invisibly.

How this kit helps

The Guide teaches the conversation. The Lab puts one new ask beside the current plan. You leave with a Priority Stack, a Displacement Map, and a Tradeoff Brief.

> Every new yes needs a plan for the work it changes. A real emergency can change the plan; it still has a consequence.

Get clear before you go back into the room.

A new urgent request can feel like disrespect for the work you've already agreed. Before responding, get clear about the actual competing outcomes.

Separate the event from your interpretation

Write the actual request, words, or decision. Then name the story you're adding about the person. You can feel frustrated and still ask a useful question about their constraints.

Name your Why

What customer, team, or company outcome does the current plan protect? What might the new request improve? You can care about both while recommending which one gets capacity now.

Paint a future they can help shape

Describe what better would look like in daily work: customers can plan, the team can focus, or decisions happen before commitments change. Invite the other person to improve the picture. A shared ambition needs their authorship too.

Keep private preparation private

The Lab saves these notes in your browser and excludes them from shared outputs. Export the working brief you want others to see; don't send your untested motive story.

> Try: I want us to make this work. Can we look together at the outcome, the constraints, and the decision we need?

Show the commitments people already rely on.

List the work before debating which stakeholder has the loudest request.

Start with the current goal

Name the outcome and the commitments supporting it. Include customer dates and dependencies rather than a list of feature names with no consequences.

Include the work outside the roadmap

Support, maintenance, review, incidents, and required approvals use capacity too. Leave room for other commitments beyond the top three in the Lab.

Check the urgent request

Ask for the timing, beneficiary, and evidence of the consequence. A Friday customer meeting is a real coordination need; a full production feature may not be the only way to meet it.

Use a common window

Compare work competing for the same team and time. Don't add story points from different teams or compare a day of engineering with a week of calendar waiting as though they were the same unit.

> Priority Stack: current commitments, the new request, why it matters now, and the capacity they share.

Make the cost of the new yes concrete.

A useful recommendation tells people who benefits, who waits, and what changes.

Name the displaced work

Say which commitment moves, shrinks, or pauses and who relies on it. If you don't know, ask the team before promising that the new request fits.

Offer more than accept or refuse

Could you narrow the request, defer it to a named checkpoint, or provide a different artifact? Describe how that alternative meets the actual need and what it costs.

Protect essential work

Keep safety, security, and acceptance requirements visible. If a new ask endangers the current goal, discuss the effect explicitly with the people who own that goal and plan.

Use the capacity check honestly

The optional Lab check adds entered person-days of existing work and the new request, then compares them with entered capacity. It is planning arithmetic, not a forecast. Unknown estimates do not become zero.

> Try: We can take this on by moving the reporting commitment. The customer then waits another week. Is that the tradeoff we want?

Recommend the move within your mandate.

A PM should bring judgment to the conversation. Make clear when you can decide and when the business tradeoff belongs elsewhere.

Use the outcome to explain the choice

I recommend a narrow demo because it supports Friday's customer conversation with less disruption than a production feature. Say which benefit justifies the cost.

Find the actual decision owner

If the trade crosses customer, funding, or policy boundaries, name the person who can decide it. Don't send every ordinary backlog choice to an executive if it is already yours to make.

Set a decision time

State when the choice is needed and what the current plan remains while waiting. Urgency should not become an unrecorded change by default.

Keep the plan coherent

Where Scrum applies, involve the Product Owner and Developers in changes to the work. A stakeholder's new request is a proposal to consider, not an independent second backlog for the team.

> Useful language: My recommendation is X because it serves Y. It changes Z. Can you confirm that tradeoff by this time?

Stay useful when everything still sounds urgent.

Treat the other person's need as legitimate. Keep the consequence visible without making the conversation a contest.

They're all top priority

Ask which outcome should get the next unit of capacity when two requests conflict. Present a sequence and its consequences. Equal labels don't resolve competition for the same time.

It will only take a day

Check implementation, review, testing, deployment, and coordination with the team. Even a small task can interrupt a larger commitment. Use an estimate with its basis rather than debating the adjective small.

Don't move anything

Show the gap in the current assumptions. Ask which scope, sequence, capacity, or date may change. If none can, record the unresolved demand and ask the owner to choose.

It's a real incident

Respond through the team's incident process. Capture the interrupted commitments, notify affected people, and re-plan when the immediate response is stable. The tool supports the follow-up tradeoff; it doesn't replace emergency procedures.

> Try: I want to support the request. Let's agree what it changes so the team and the affected customer get one clear plan.

A Friday demo meets a full week.

Fictional case: an executive requests a customer demo midweek. The same team is finishing onboarding, a security review, and a reporting update.

The Priority Stack

For the stated planning window, the team enters 10 available person-days, 10 person-days of existing work, and 2 for the demo including review. Entered demand is 12, leaving a 2-person-day gap before displacement.

The Displacement Map

PM recommends a narrow demo and moving 2 person-days of reporting work. Onboarding and the security review remain protected. Reporting's customer update must change.

The alternative

Keep the reporting commitment and use the existing prototype in Friday's meeting. The prototype can support feedback, but it cannot demonstrate a finished production workflow.

The decision and follow-through

In this fictional case, the sponsor chooses the narrow demo with reporting displacement Wednesday. PM records the choice and updates the team and reporting stakeholder Thursday. They review the result Friday. The Lab example starts before that agreement; the arithmetic supports the conversation, not a promised delivery date.

> One request enters, named work moves, and the affected people receive one coherent plan.

Put the request beside the work, then export the choice.

Use your Priority Whiplash Lab before or during a priority conversation. Nic's walkthrough shows the same instrument on a realistic example.

The Stack

Enter the current goal, commitments, other work, and new request. Check the urgency. Private reflection stays out of shared records. Build the Priority Stack when you need to show the competing work.

Displacement

Choose accept, narrow, defer, or decline as a recommendation. Name what changes, the consequence, protected work, and an alternative. Add the optional capacity assumptions when they help.

Recommend

Explain your choice and name the decision owner and needed-by date. Export the Displacement Map for discussion.

Record

Set the decision status and enter what was actually agreed. Name communication and review owners. Export the Tradeoff Brief to your team's existing work tools; the Lab doesn't change the backlog itself.

> Load the fictional example to rehearse. Keep your own important draft by exporting it before replacement.

Use the next conversation to learn.

A useful brief changes what happens next. Give it an owner, take it into your existing work tools, and return to the evidence.

Follow through on one move

Check that the new choice changed the actual plan and the affected stakeholder communication. Review whether the displacement was sufficient. If new work enters again, reuse the same visible tradeoff rather than starting a hidden plan.

Rehearse with a trusted peer

Read your opening aloud. Ask: Is the observation fair? Is the recommendation specific? Could the other person disagree without being cast as the villain? Revise the wording before the real conversation.

Keep a record you can return to

Lab drafts stay in this browser on this device. Copy, download, or print your outputs. Export before clearing browser data or moving devices. The tool does not send messages, update your roadmap, or create authority.

Judge the change by what happens

What did the other person hear? Was a decision made? Did anyone act? Review the next real result rather than treating completion of the Lab as proof that the organizational problem is solved.

> You arrive with a situation. You leave with a proposal, a decision record, or a specific question that somebody can act on.